

Mav and the Upside-Down Beaver

Maverick crouched behind a pile of slimy, vine-covered bicycles in the **Inside Out**. Everything looked like Clovis, but if Clovis had been left at the bottom of a damp lake for a century. He could hear the clicking sounds of the **Demogorgons**—which looked like giant, angry Venus Flytraps with six-packs—patrolling the nearby mall.

"I knew I shouldn't have played with that weird radio," Mav whispered. "Now I'm in a dimension that smells like wet dog and industrial-strength basement mold."

Suddenly, the air rippled. **Taffy Stamburger** appeared, wearing his signature trenchcoat and using a greasy surgical glove to literally peel back the fabric of reality.

"Hurry up, kid!" Taffy rasped, smelling like flat grape soda and cosmic static. "I can only hold this portal open as long as I can think about ham sandwiches!"

Stepping through the portal was **Professor Balthazar Bucktooth**. He was wearing a tiny pink dress and a blonde wig, looking exactly like Eleven if she were a semi-aquatic rodent with a passion for dams. He had a single drop of blood dripping from his nose.

"Stand back, Maverick!" the Professor bellowed. "The structural integrity of this dimension is offensive to my sensibilities! I shall dismantle it with the power of my mind and my incredible tail!"

Bucktooth closed his eyes, his whiskers vibrating with telekinetic energy. "I CALL UPON THE BLUBBER! WALRUSES OF THE WEST COAST, HEAR MY RADIATED WHISPER!"

From out of the portal surged a wet, barking army. Hundreds of **Walruses**, led by a battle-hardened **Waltrude**, slid into the Inside Out on a layer of mysterious festive grease.

"FOR THE FISH STICKS!" Waltrude roared, tackling a Demogorgon and pinning it to the ground with her sheer blubber-mass.

The battle was absolute chaos. The Demogorgons tried to lunge, but Bucktooth used his powers to telekinetically slap them with spectral cedar planks. Taffy Stamburger threw exploding boxes of raisins at the Mind Flayer—a giant monster made of shadow and discarded dryer lint—while the walrus army used their flippers to deliver thunderous "Belly-Flops of Justice."

"You call this a monster?!" Bucktooth mocked, levitating a Demodog and spinning it like a ceiling fan. "Your skeletal structure is amateurish! Your joints lack proper lubrication! You are a walking building code violation!"

With a final, massive psychic "Hmph!", the Professor caused the Mind Flayer to implode into a pile of very confused kittens. The portal flared bright purple.

"Let's go, Mav!" Adrian yelled, popping his head through the portal wearing a Pterodactyl mask. "The pizza is getting cold!"

They tumbled back into Maverick's bedroom, the portal snapping shut behind them with the sound of a closing Ziploc bag. The room was warm, dry, and distinctly lack-of-monsters.

Mav, the Professor, Adrian, and Taffy sat around a table littered with dice and character sheets.

"Okay," Mav said, rolling a d20. "I cast Fireball at the Orc."

"Incorrect!" the Professor snapped. "You must first analyze the Orc's foundational stance! If his feet aren't shoulder-width apart, you can simply push him over with a stiff breeze! It's basic physics, Maverick!"

Mav looked at the Professor, who was now translucent blue again and eating a ghostly taco. "Professor, I have to ask. Are you actually dead? We had a funeral. There were Muppets. You're a Force Ghost. But you just fought a lint-monster in a pink dress."

Bucktooth paused, a taco shell hovering near his whiskers. "Dead is a very binary term, Maverick. Is a dam 'dead' because it is still? No! It is a monument to potential energy!"

"That's not an answer," Mav said. "Are you a ghost or are you just very, very good at hiding?"

The Professor let out a long, mysterious whistle. "Look, a bird!" He pointed at the ceiling. When Mav looked back, the Professor had changed into a tiny tuxedo and was busy rearranging Mav's bookshelves by height and Dewey Decimal code.

"You're avoiding the question!" Mav yelled.

"I am avoiding the structural collapse of this conversation!" Bucktooth replied. "Now, roll for initiative! I believe a Walrus-Orc is approaching the tavern, and he is very hungry for corporate bonuses!"

Mav sighed, exchanged a look with Adrian—who was eating an emotional support Twinkie—and decided that whether the beaver was dead, alive, or a hallucination caused by bad mustard, he was definitely the best Dungeon Master in Clovis.